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# THE BOMB SHIP OFF SHEERNESS

SS RICHARD MONTGOMERY · 1944 → TODAY

STATUS: OPEN · CARGO STILL ABOARD



FREE FIELD EDITION · 11 PAGES
FACTS CHECKED TO 16 OCT 2026
EVERY CLAIM GRADED AND SOURCED

Cover: artist's impression (AI-assisted) of the wreck before its masts were removed in Sept 2026. Not to scale; the real wreck lies in two sections.

THE CASE IN 60 SECONDS

# 82 YEARS OF “DON'T TOUCH IT”

In August 1944 an American cargo ship full of bombs dragged its anchor at the mouth of the Thames, ran onto a sandbank and broke her back. About half the cargo was taken off. The rest is still there: roughly **1,400 tons of explosive filling**, 1.5 miles from the town of Sheerness. For eighty-two years the official advice has been the same: watch it, guard it, and do not disturb it. In September 2026 salvors finally cut into the wreck itself, to take away the three masts that had been sticking out of the water since the war.

**~1,400 t**
EXPLOSIVE FILLING (NEQ) STILL ABOARD

**1.5 mi**
FROM SHEERNESS · 5 MI FROM SOUTHEND

**16 days**
TO CUT AWAY 3 MASTS, 15–30 SEP 2026

## CASE CARD

| ITEM | RECORD | GRADE |
|---|---|---|
| Ship | US Liberty ship, 7,146 gross tons, built 1943 by St John's River Shipbuilding Co., Jacksonville, Florida | VERIFIED |
| Grounded | 20 Aug 1944, Sheerness Middle Sand, after anchoring at the Great Nore while waiting for a convoy to Cherbourg | VERIFIED |
| Salvage stopped | 25 Sep 1944, with “approximately half” the cargo removed | VERIFIED |
| Still aboard | ~1,400 tons net explosive quantity in holds 1, 2 and 3 (forward section) | VERIFIED |
| Depth / position | ~15 m of water, in two sections, on what is believed to be London clay. Centre of restricted area EG R162 (SI 2026/54): 51°27′58″N 0°47′12″E | VERIFIED |
| Who owns it | Still the property of the United States government | VERIFIED |
| Who looks after it | UK Department for Transport; annual surveys by the Maritime and Coastguard Agency; 24-hour radar watch by Medway Ports | VERIFIED |
| Legal status | Dangerous wreck under the Protection of Wrecks Act 1973 (SI 1973/1690). Entering the prohibited area without written permission is an offence | VERIFIED |

## WHAT CHANGED IN 2026

A £9.5 million government contract paid salvors to cut off the masts, whose weight was straining the rotting deck above the holds. Work began on **15 September**; the last mast came off just before 5 pm on **30 September**. The masts are going to the Historic Dockyard Chatham. **The bombs stay.** There is no plan to remove the cargo.

**How to read the grades.** VERIFIED primary record opened, or two independent primary sources. ATTRIBUTED one outlet reports it; we say who. CONFLICT sources disagree; we show both. UNVERIFIED widely repeated, not proven; we don't state it as fact.

TIMELINE

# FROM LAUNCH TO LAST MAST

## THE SHIP

**1943**
Built in Jacksonville, Florida, one of more than 2,700 mass-produced Liberty ships. VERIFIED Named after Richard Montgomery, the Irish-born general killed attacking Quebec in 1775. ATTRIBUTED

**SUMMER 1944**
Crosses the Atlantic in convoy HX-301, loaded with munitions. (Convoy records say it left New York on 25 July; the MCA's recent reports say “August”.) CONFLICT

## THE GROUNDING

**20 AUG 1944**
Ordered to anchor at the Great Nore, water too shallow for her load. She drags her anchor on a falling tide and grounds on Sheerness Middle Sand. That evening the hull plates split with “an explosive like sound”. VERIFIED

**23 AUG 1944**
Stevedores start unloading. Next day the hull cracks further and the forward holds flood. VERIFIED

**8 SEP 1944**
She breaks her back completely. VERIFIED

**25 SEP 1944**
Salvage abandoned with about half the cargo out. VERIFIED

## THE LONG WATCH

**22 JUL 1967**
A different ammunition wreck, the *Kielce*, explodes during salvage off Folkestone, registering about magnitude 4½ on seismographs. The lesson sticks: don't disturb the Montgomery. VERIFIED

**15 MAY 1970**
A government study models the worst case: a column of water and debris nearly 3,000 m high and broken windows across Sheerness. ATTRIBUTED

**31 OCT 1973**
Designated a dangerous wreck under the new Protection of Wrecks Act. VERIFIED

**OCT 1999**
Rigging trimmed from the masts above the waterline. VERIFIED

**2018 → 2023**
Expert group recommends cutting the masts (2018). Contractor sought (2020). Seabed surveys find more legacy munitions, so the project pauses (2023). VERIFIED

## 2025–2026

**2025 SURVEY**
Part of the wreck around the bridge and boiler room has collapsed, shifting about 2 m (1.2 m downward) in a year. VERIFIED

**MAY 2025 → FEB 2026**
Low flying over the wreck banned from May 2025; made permanent on 19 Feb 2026 as restricted area EG R162 (below 13,200 ft within 0.5 nautical miles). VERIFIED

**18 MAR 2026**
£9.5 m contract awarded to Resolve Salvage & Fire (Europe) Ltd. Three firms bid. VERIFIED

**15–30 SEP 2026**
Work starts on 15 September. VERIFIED Divers cut with a diamond wire saw, chosen for its low vibration (Washington Post). ATTRIBUTED Masts lifted on 20 and 24 September (KentOnline). ATTRIBUTED The last comes off on 30 September, just before 5 pm. VERIFIED

THE SITE FROM SPACE

# WHERE IT SITS




Copernicus Sentinel-2 image, 25 Aug 2026, 10 m resolution (contains modified Copernicus Sentinel data 2026). At this resolution the wreck itself is not visible. The marker is the centre of restricted area EG R162 (SI 2026/54, 51°27′58″N 0°47′12″E); the diamond is drawn from the SI 1973/1690 corner coordinates.

## THE EXCLUSION ZONE

The legal “prohibited area” is a four-cornered diamond, roughly 430 m north–south by 400 m east–west by our calculation. News reports often say “500 metres”. It is marked by four lit cardinal buoys and twelve red danger buoys, and it was temporarily enlarged for the 2026 works. VERIFIED

| CORNER | LAT | LONG |
|---|---|---|
| N | 51°28′04″N | 0°47′12″E |
| E | 51°27′57″N | 0°47′22″E |
| S | 51°27′50″N | 0°47′11″E |
| W | 51°27′58″N | 0°47′01″E |

## WHY HERE MATTERS

The wreck sits a few hundred metres from the Medway approach channel, and the Washington Post reports “thousands of vessels” pass each year. ATTRIBUTED It actually helps navigation: the MCA notes it marks the sandbank it grounded on. VERIFIED

The sky above it is closed too. Low flying has been banned since May 2025, and since 19 February 2026 restricted area EG R162 permanently bars aircraft, drones included, below 13,200 ft within half a nautical mile, except emergency or permitted flights. VERIFIED

INVENTORY

# WHAT IS STILL ON BOARD

“1,400 tons” is the government's estimate of **net explosive quantity**: the weight of the explosive filling alone, not of the bombs and their steel casings. VERIFIED Counting casings, the UK Hydrographic Office's older wreck index puts the remaining cargo nearer 3,500 tons.

ATTRIBUTED

## THE BEST ESTIMATE OF THE CARGO LEFT IN THE FORWARD HOLDS

| HOLD | WHAT THE 2000 MCA REPORT LISTS (A DEFENCE RESEARCH AGENCY ESTIMATE) |
|---|---|
| No. 1 | 1,407 × 500 lb, 850 × 1,000 lb and 1,500 × 250 lb TNT bombs; 1,429 cases of 100 lb white-phosphorus smoke bombs; signals and boosters |
| No. 2 | 286 × 2,000 lb general-purpose bombs; 1,068 × 1,000 lb and 574 × 500 lb semi-armour-piercing bombs; 588 × 1,000 lb bombs; 521–580 × 260 lb fragmentation bombs and 2,297 cases of fragmentation cluster bombs |
| No. 3 | 1,170 × 1,000 lb semi-armour-piercing, 406 × 1,000 lb general-purpose and 1,351 × 500 lb semi-armour-piercing bombs. Its 'tween deck still holds 86 tons of fuses in 1,522 wooden cases (MCA, 2025) |

Source: MCA, Report on the wreck of the SS Richard Montgomery (Nov 2000), Appendix 1; MCA annual survey report 2025. Estimates, not a manifest.

### IS IT GETTING WORSE?

The steel is. The 2025 survey found the area around the bridge and boiler room had collapsed, shifting about 2 m (1.2 m of it downward) in a single year, and the forward section keeps tilting east. Between 2022 and 2024 the top of the foremast moved 43–55 cm. VERIFIED

The government says deterioration is expected and “there is no indication that the risk has increased”. VERIFIED

### WHAT THE EXPERTS WORRY ABOUT

A defence research review after the 1996 survey (published 2000) found TNT stable in water. The old fear, that fuses would form sensitive copper azide, was judged minor because the fuses are flooded. White phosphorus is stable underwater but can ignite if it reaches the air. About 800 fused cluster bombs are believed to remain. VERIFIED

Why the masts had to go: their weight strained the deck plating, and a collapse could have fallen into a cargo hold. VERIFIED

THE BIG QUESTION

# HOW BIG WOULD THE BANG BE?

The official line has not changed in decades: the risk of a major explosion is believed to be "remote". VERIFIED What has changed is the government's own estimate of the worst case.

1970 STUDY

## ~3,000 m

COLUMN OF WATER, MUD AND DEBRIS

A government study, as later reported by the BBC, imagined a column about 300 m wide reaching almost 3,000 m (10,000 ft), almost every window in Sheerness broken and a wave around 16 ft (5 m). ATTRIBUTED

2026 REMODELLING

## Windows

"MINOR BREAKAGES TO SINGLE-GLAZED WINDOWS"

New modelling, peer-reviewed by Ministry of Defence experts and described to Parliament on 21 April 2026, says even the worst case means limited onshore damage, no debris reaching Sheerness, and waves unlikely to breach flood defences. VERIFIED

> *"Damage onshore is likely to be limited to potential minor breakages to single-glazed windows, with no debris expected to reach Sheerness or any other town."*
>
> Lilian Greenwood MP for the DfT, House of Commons, 21 Apr 2026 (Hansard)

## THE PRECEDENT EVERYONE REMEMBERS

On 22 July 1967 salvors fired a cutting charge on the *Kielce*, a much smaller ammunition ship sunk off Folkestone in 1946. The cargo went off. At least 25 observatories recorded it, as far as nearly 5,000 miles away, at about magnitude 4½. It left a crater 20 ft deep; chimneys and ceilings were damaged ashore, but nobody was hurt. The MCA's 2000 report quotes the scene: it "brought panic to Folkestone's town and chaos to the beaches". VERIFIED

**Our read.** Both models are real documents; they answer different questions with different methods and 56 years apart. Nobody has ever been willing to test either one, which is the whole reason the cargo is still there.

MYTH-CHECK

# WHERE THE SOURCES DISAGREE

The Montgomery is one of the most-repeated wreck stories in Britain, and the numbers drift with every retelling. Here is what the record actually says.

| CLAIM YOU'LL SEE | WHAT THE RECORD SAYS | BEST ANSWER |
|---|---|---|
| "1,400 tonnes of bombs" | 1,400 tons is the explosive *filling* (net explosive quantity). With casings it is far more. Some sites even say 7,000 tonnes remain; that was the whole cargo when she grounded. | "About 1,400 tons of explosives" |
| "Cutting began on 29 September" | Work started on 15 September. 29 September is the date of the salvage company's press release, by which time two masts were already off. | 15–30 Sep 2026 |
| Cargo when she grounded | ~7,000 tons (MCA background note) vs 6,127 imperial tons (MCA 2025 report) vs 6,862 tons (UK Hydrographic Office). | "More than 6,000 tons" |
| Distance from shore | 1.5 miles / 2.4 km (MCA, DfT, BBC 2026) vs 1.2 miles (BBC, 2011–12). | 1.5 miles |
| "A 500 m exclusion zone" | The legal zone is a diamond of about 430 × 400 m (our calculation from the statutory coordinates). | "A few hundred metres" |
| Amount salvaged in 1944 | 2,954 tons (MCA 2025) vs 3,173 tons (UKHO) vs "about half" (MCA background). | "About half" |
| "The whole crew survived" | No primary source we found says so. The MCA says only that no explosions occurred during grounding or salvage. | Unproven UNVERIFIED |
| "Attacked by German aircraft" | One line in an old UK Hydrographic Office index. It contradicts every MCA account. | Don't use UNVERIFIED |
| "14,000 bombs" and "strange lights" | Widely repeated online; not in the official inventory in this form. | Unproven UNVERIFIED |
| Yearly cost of watching it | No figure has been published. The DfT's own accounts call the potential cost "unquantifiable". | Unknown |

FOLLOW THE MONEY

# WHO PAYS, WHO DECIDES

**£9.5 m**
MAST CONTRACT, EXCL. VAT

**3**
TENDERS RECEIVED

**“Unquantifiable”**
DFT'S WORD FOR THE POTENTIAL COST

## THE CONTRACT

The Department for Transport tendered the “SS Richard Montgomery Mast Reduction Project” in November 2025 at an estimated £10 m. The winner, on 18 March 2026, was Resolve Salvage & Fire (Europe) Ltd of Eastbourne, part of the Resolve Marine group, at £9.5 m. The contract was signed on 7 May 2026 and runs to 31 March 2027, extendable to 2028. The cutting itself took sixteen days. VERIFIED

## THE BILL NOBODY CAN SIZE

The DfT's 2025–26 accounts carry the wreck as a possible obligation: it has paid for marking, guarding, inspections and mitigation, and says the potential cost “is considered to be unquantifiable”. No official estimate exists for removing the cargo, because the long-standing advice is that trying would raise the very risk everyone wants to avoid. VERIFIED

## THE ODD LEGAL POSITION

**American property, British problem.** The wreck still belongs to the US government; the UK has taken “de facto responsibility” for it since the war, first through the Board of Trade and, since 1983, the Department of Transport. VERIFIED

**The masts are on loan.** KentOnline reports the US government has loaned the masts to the Historic Dockyard Chatham. In June 2026 the US ambassador welcomed keeping them in the UK for public display. ATTRIBUTED

This file explains how the money and law work. It is not financial or legal advice.

OPEN CASE

# WHAT TO WATCH NEXT

The masts are gone, but the case is not closed. These are the dated, checkable things that will tell you how the story moves.

| WHEN | WHAT TO LOOK FOR | WHERE IT WILL APPEAR |
|---|---|---|
| By 31 Oct 2026 | Notice to Mariners No. 41 (marine operations at the site) expires. A new notice, or none, tells you whether work on site has ended. | Peel Ports London Medway notices |
| Any day | A formal "project complete" statement. As of 16 Oct 2026 we found none from the DfT or MCA. | gov.uk news; MCA wreck page |
| Next annual survey | Whether removing the masts slowed the collapse around Key Area 6, and whether the forward section is still tilting east. | MCA annual survey report on gov.uk |
| 2026–27 | Where the masts end up on public display. Conservation at Chatham comes first; the final site was not decided when we checked. | Chatham Historic Dockyard Trust; local press |
| To 31 Mar 2027 | The contract window. Watch for extensions to 2028 or follow-on work. | Find a Tender service |

## SEEING IT FOR YOURSELF, SAFELY AND LEGALLY

- [ ] You can see the site from the Sheerness seafront. Since the masts came down, the ring of buoys is the main thing to see.
- [ ] Local boat trips have run past the zone, according to the BBC; operators and schedules change, so check directly. Boats must stay outside the buoys. ATTRIBUTED
- [ ] Never enter the prohibited area. It is an offence without the Transport Secretary's written permission. VERIFIED
- [ ] Don't fly a drone near it: restricted area EG R162 covers anything below 13,200 ft within half a nautical mile. VERIFIED
- [ ] For the masts themselves, follow the Historic Dockyard Chatham, which is conserving them.

**Case updates.** When something on this list happens, we update this file. Subscribers hear about it first, and Complete Edition buyers get the updated edition free.

SOURCES

# CHECK OUR WORK

Primary records first (government reports, legislation, contracts, Parliament), then named news reports. Quoted words are short extracts for reference and comment, attributed to their source. Contains public sector information licensed under the Open Government Licence v3.0 (nationalarchives.gov.uk/doc/open-government-licence/version/3/). Contains Parliamentary information licensed under the Open Parliament Licence v3.0. Map contains modified Copernicus Sentinel data 2026.


1. **MCA, The SS Richard Montgomery: information and survey reports (hub, updated 11 Mar 2026).** https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-ss-richard-montgomery-information-and-survey-reports
2. **MCA, SS Richard Montgomery: background information.** https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-ss-richard-montgomery-information-and-survey-reports/ss-richard-montgomery-background-information
3. **MCA, Annual survey report 2025.** https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/699c2f41d2b9c6ec5b6fbb84/SS-richard-montgomery-annual-survey-report-2025.pdf
4. **MCA, Annual survey report 2024.** https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/682ee07ea599d03a16bff3e1/SS_Richard_Montgomery_annual_survey_report_2024.pdf
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6. **DfT press release, 14 Jul 2026: safe removal of masts begins.** https://www.gov.uk/government/news/safe-removal-of-masts-from-historic-wwii-shipwreck-carrying-wartime-explosives-begins
7. **Hansard, Commons debate "SS Richard Montgomery: Masts", 21 Apr 2026.** https://hansard.parliament.uk/commons/2026-04-21/debates/B77998A2-DE0D-4BE8-A5F1-A00DD4A782F8/SSRichardMontgomeryMasts
8. **SI 1973/1690, Protection of Wrecks (Designation No. 2) Order 1973.** https://www.legislation.gov.uk/uksi/1973/1690/made
9. **SI 2026/54, restricted airspace EG R162.** https://www.legislation.gov.uk/uksi/2026/54/made
10. **Find a Tender, contract award notice 027999-2026.** https://www.find-tender.service.gov.uk/Notice/027999-2026
11. **DfT Annual Report and Accounts 2025–26.** https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a60c4c847af652afa0c8a10/dft-annual-report-25-26.pdf
12. **Peel Ports London Medway, Notice to Mariners No. 41 of 2026 (via MSBA).** https://msba.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2026/09/NtoM-No-41-of-2026-River-Medway-SS-Richard-Montgomery-Planned-Masts-Removel-Works.pdf
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14. **BBC News, 1 Oct 2026: masts removed.** https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c6wyz44x4g33o
15. **BBC News, 3 Oct 2026: A deadly secret in the Thames.** https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cqg7x983e54lo
16. **KentOnline, 1 Oct 2026: final mast removed.** https://www.kentonline.co.uk/sheerness/news/end-of-an-era-as-final-mast-of-iconic-sunken-bomb-ship-off-k-345776/
17. **Washington Post, 4 Oct 2026 (syndicated, Anchorage Daily News).** https://www.adn.com/nation-world/2026/10/04/us-shipwreck-laden-with-world-war-ii-munitions-is-a-time-bomb-near-london/
18. **warsailors.com, Convoy HX 301 (citing Arnold Hague).** https://warsailors.com/convoys/hx301.html
19. **Copernicus Sentinel-2 L2A, 25 Aug 2026, tile 31UCT.** https://dataspace.copernicus.eu/


**How this file was made.** A fact desk opened the primary records, graded 94 individual claims, and flagged every conflict. This free edition carries the essentials. Spotted an error? Reply to the email this file came with and we'll correct it and credit you.

**Independence and safety.** Vibe with Judeo is an independent documentary channel, not affiliated with the DfT, MCA, Resolve Marine or any body named here. Nothing in this file is an invitation to approach the wreck.

THAT WAS THE FREE EDITION

# THE FULL CASE FILES

One case file for each new Vibe with Judeo documentary, starting with four at launch and adding more each week. The Complete Edition adds the full evidence, and is re-issued when a case moves.

**FREE FIELD EDITION**

- [ ] The case in 60 seconds
- [ ] Timeline, map and case card
- [ ] Myth-check table
- [ ] What to watch next
- [ ] Key sources

**COMPLETE EDITION**

- [ ] Everything in the free edition
- [ ] The full graded fact register (this case: 94 claims, each with its source and link)
- [ ] Evidence pack: key passages from the primary records, cited
- [ ] Printable large-format site chart
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